

VALUES → PRINCIPLES → BEHAVIORS

2019

One critical component of the path of initiation is understanding how you came to be the person that you are.⁵³ At a high-level, our behaviors are always a result of our thoughts.⁵⁴ So what we think is what we do and what we do is who we are. The same goes for what we say. However, what we do is given more weight in terms of defining who we are as people.

So if we want to change our behaviors, we must change our thoughts. But in order to change our thoughts, we must understand what's wrong with them. This can get very nebulous very quickly. So in order to put a reasonable framework around that effort, we begin by creating a list of values. These are the things that we believe are good and should be preserved or amplified in the world. These may or may not include references to your belief system to serve as justification or context. It

⁵³ Not necessarily the person you believe yourself to be.

⁵⁴ Ignoring the autonomic nervous system for the moment

doesn't have to be a long list. Ten to twenty is plenty.

Then, from that list of values, create a list of principles. These are things that a person can do that help to promote one or more of the listed values. Try to keep the list under 100 so it's at least possible to memorize.

Finally, behaviors are derived from the list of principles. While the principles refer to actions, they are generic. Behaviors are the circumstantial implementations of one or more principles. There's no point in trying to make a list of behaviors. These must be determined on the spot as situations arise. At first, this will require a pause to consciously consider what behavior is most appropriate. But with practice, it becomes subconscious and automatic. When that occurs, you have succeeded in becoming a new person, the person you really want to be: Your best self.

To seed your efforts to define a personal set of values, consider the four Beauchamp and Childress principles⁵⁵ of biomedical ethics: autonomy, beneficence, non-maleficence, and justice. Many published examples of these values (or metavalues) are confusing because they apply these values inconsistently, sometimes applying to the person and other times applying to other people the person interacts with. So, take this example that is focused just on the self. The values you choose to apply to and respect in other people is a whole different discussion.

- Autonomy: The freedom to express oneself, to move, to create, to consume, to love without intervention or restriction placed by any other person.
- Beneficence: The freedom to help others and make the world a better place.

⁵⁵ Tom L. Beauchamp and James F. Childress, *Principles of Biomedical Ethics*, 8th ed. (New York: Oxford University Press, 2019).

Severin Aequus

- Non-Maleficence: The restriction to not intentionally harm others.
- Justice: The restriction to treat others as fairly and equitably as possible. Speak truthfully and honestly.

Clearly, these are not values you would want to adopt at face value, which is why I alluded to them above as metavalues. They could also be described as archetypal values or maybe even taxonomies of values. However you choose to perceive them, they are too broad in scope and would require too many qualifiers to be taken as values directly, but they should prove valuable in helping you to get started and brainstorm related values.

That's kind of helpful but still not really? You need a concrete example of what a finished list of values looks like?

I generally don't reveal what values I live by until the other person has done theirs first. Partly, this is to avoid mindless copycatting. But also this is because my values are carefully worded in order to align with my personal worldview and my unique purpose for existing, which isn't always a Utopian, Kumbaya vision. But for the sake of clarity and transparency, here they are. Again, this is not the "correct" answer, it's **my** answer and mine alone.

I will further point out that my personal values were not designed to be generalized and might result in complete societal collapse if they were to be adopted wholesale by everyone. But it illustrates the point that you should not even aspire to define a list of universal values, only the values that work for you as one person. There is no set of values that serve society as a whole without greatly compromising the individual. If there were, then I would simply publish that list and call it a day. Instead, we must each take on this work for ourselves. Without further ado...

I live by the following values:

Honesty : When I consider that we each live in our unique reality built upon our understanding of the common elements we each perceive, I begin to comprehend the profound harm caused by deceiving one another about the facts of how the world works or the actions of individuals within it. In order to ensure the ability of all people to make sound choices based on a best possible understanding of the world, I value honesty.

Compassion : When I look into the substance of who we are, I find that we are all parts of one eternal living organism. Therefore, elevating myself requires elevating the whole. Therefore, I value compassion.

Non-Materialism : I have learned that material possessions, beyond the basics required to live and work, do nothing to support long-term happiness or productivity. In fact, they nearly always have the opposite effect. For that reason, I value non-materialism.

Freedom : The fact that other people exist suggests that I do not (and cannot?) fully know their minds. This suggests that I am in no position to determine what is right for another person. Therefore, I value freedom of speech and action (even if it results in harming others).

Non-Procreation : As I observe the behaviors of people on a global scale, I see that we are still struggling with how to divide and distribute natural resources, including our own labor, fairly and equitably. For this reason, I value non-procreation as a means of limiting the harm done until such time that we learn to live in harmony with the Earth and each other.

Cooperation : I have found that I am more effective in accomplishing

my goals when I work with others who share similar values. Therefore, I value cooperation and meaningful relationships.

Recreation : In order to not only develop and maintain meaningful relationships with others, but also to ensure my own psychological well-being, I value recreation.

Education : I have found that I am more effective in accomplishing my goals when I am better educated. For this reason, I value lifelong learning.

Modesty : I have found that people who boast and brag do so because they are fundamentally insecure and afraid. Therefore, I value being secure in who I am and using modesty as a means to measure my effectiveness in this effort.

Respect : I have observed that the coercion of others is wrong, particularly when money is the weapon of choice. Therefore, I value respecting the autonomy of others and promoting voluntary activities, organizations, and social structures.

Non-Attachment : The only constant is change. Therefore I value non-attachment to the extent that it does not diminish my appreciation of the moment.

Mindfulness : I understand that time is an illusion. The past is not only unchangeable, it is also unique for every person. Living with the mind stuck in the past results in regret and nostalgia for a time which will never come again. The future has not been revealed yet and only occasionally even works on a probabilistic basis knowable by any person. Living with a mind stuck in the future results in stress and worry. Logically, the only thing that is real is now, since it is the only thing we have the ability to directly influence. Therefore, I value

mindfulness and living in the present.

If at any time you feel the need to check how well you are doing, you can audit your daily behaviors for some period of time and then go through one-by-one and show a logical chain of causality back to one or more values. If you cannot, then you still have work to do.

Conversely, if you find that you're having difficulties determining what your values are, look at your behaviors. What values do they imply? Start there.

CLARIFICATIONS AND EXCEPTIONS

Honesty

Default Rule:

I tell the truth even when it's inconvenient for me.

Exception 1 (Non-Maleficence):

If a truth would harm you *and* give you no tangible or strategic benefit, I'll substitute a neutral falsehood rather than wound you needlessly.

Exception 2 (Crisis Override):

If you're about to harm yourself in a state of emotional turbulence, I will say or do what's necessary to stop you, even if it requires temporary deception. Once you're safe, truth resumes.

Omission Policy:

By default, I reserve the right to omit information. Full disclosure is not automatic. If your emotional well-being rests on being able to trust me with no omissions, that must be explicitly negotiated, and I will then abide by it.

Corollary:

You don't have an automatic right to every fact I know. My obligation is to act in your best interest and in accordance with our agreed terms, not to dump data indiscriminately.

Non-Materialism

Definition:

Non-Materialism, as I'm using it here, doesn't mean that I can't own anything. It's not an eschewing of personal ownership in theory or practice. Instead, it places certain limits on what I can own and my relationship with those items.

Function:

All possessions must serve a purpose. They should be classifiable as either tools or materials.

Tools: Durable goods that have a recognized function that improves life either through augmentation of human physical ability or directly enhancing the conditions of our survival.

Usefulness:

All possessions must be things I can and likely will make use of even if not in use presently. For example, a piano meets the definition of a tool for creating music. But if I don't know how to play the piano and am not making any effort to learn, then I should not own it.

Pleasure:

Owning a thing you derive no joy from only because you believe that it will appreciate in value is a violation of this principle. For example, owning a first edition of Principia Mathematica by Isaac Newton that you gleefully show to anyone who visits (after they wear the cotton

gloves you give them, of course) is not a violation. The box of baseball cards you think might be in the attic somewhere is.

Unique:

Items which are unique are exempted from this rule. For clarity, unique does not mean, rare or unusual. Unique means: "This is literally the only one in the world. If I lose it or it is destroyed, then humanity no longer has one of these." Aside from their 6-year-old's art project, most people do not own a unique item. But in general, original works of art (even if prints exist), most pre-Industrial antiques, and anything personally designed and constructed qualify under this exception.

Test 1:

If this item were stolen from me, would I buy another just like it?

Test 2:

If an item has not demonstrated its purpose in the last year and there is no definite plan to use it in the future (e.g. "I want to drive my dad's old car, but it's broken and I'm waiting to save the money to have it repaired") then it must go.

Freedom

Disclaimer:

It's important to bear in mind that these are my values and are presented here only to serve as an example, not a list to be duplicated.

Preconditions:

This value makes sense for *me* because I meet a specific set of preconditions necessary for such a value to not end badly (in an ethical sense). These are:

1. *Defense Only*: I never have the right to harm or kill a person who is not an imminent threat to my or someone else's life.
2. *Last Resort*: All practical, non-lethal means to resolve a dispute must be attempted before resorting to lethal force. As a corollary to this condition, a person need not put my life in imminent danger in order to illicit a lethal response (See example below).
3. *Values-Behavior Alignment*: This is a recursive condition, which is a little confusing. Basically, it presupposes that I have already completed this exercise and have successfully aligned my behaviors with my values. Therefore if I were to injure someone, that act too would have to be in alignment with my values and is therefore (at least ethically) defensible.
4. *Benevolent Intent*: I must have a high degree of confidence in the accuracy and completeness of the situational information I have at hand AND must act in the best interest of society, not of myself only, before taking hostile action.
5. *Responsible and Effective Application of Force*: I must have received proper training related to any weapon I may have at my disposal including no weapon at all. A lack of knowledge, training, or practice precludes my ability to use that means of defense. If that rule eliminates every possible avenue of attack, then I am placing myself at my attacker's mercy. Every effort should be taken to avoid this scenario.

Examples (assuming you took this value for yourself):

1. During a trip to a foreign country, you were abducted and are

being held in a makeshift prison staffed by a rebel militia. You are not being charged with any crime; you are being held for ransom. Your captors have made a comfortable cabin for you and you are provided with good food and drink. You even have a TV and a comfy bed. There are armed guards preventing you from leaving the compound, but no one bothers you in your cabin. If the opportunity presented itself, would you have the ethical right (or even obligation) to kill every last one of those motherfuckers?

- a. What about their wives and children? The doctors and clergy?
2. You're attending a festival and a man in the crowd ducks into a vendor stall and emerges with an
 3. AR-15 and begins firing into the crowd. For whatever reason, you happen to be armed and trained in the use of your weapon. You are in an odd vantage point to have a clear line-of-sight on the shooter. There is no one between you two and no one behind him, from your angle, who could be shot if you miss. Would you take the shot?
 4. What if the crowd of people were all Nazis disguised as festival-goers?
 5. For some reason, you're walking alone in a dark, deserted alley at night when a man steps out from behind a dumpster and blocks your path. He has a 9" chef's knife in his hand. You have a loaded and chambered pistol in your belt. He says, "Just hand it over. You know how this works." Do you:
 - a. Hand the man your wallet
 - b. Try to shoot the knife out of his hand

Severin Aequus

- c. Shoot him in the knee and run away
- d. Shoot to kill

Examples Analysis:

1. Yes, you kill everyone who is in a position to restrict your ability to leave the compound. In practical terms, that would mean everyone with a weapon.
2. If they attempt to prevent you from leaving, they must die. If they stand aside, they must not be harmed. However, this does open up the possibility of being killed by a covert operative using a concealed weapon. But if that happens, then it happens. The ethical burden of killing innocent people is too great to simply kill everyone on the suspicion that one of them might be a covert operative.
3. Of course you have to take the shot.
4. You had no way to know that. A person committing a lone, premeditated act of mass murder is seldom in the right, so your action was the right one to a very large degree of statistical certainty. Also, there was no way that everyone in that random crowd - that you yourself could have easily been in - were Nazis. The man was firing randomly. He either did or would have killed innocent people.
5. Assuming that you could successfully shoot him in the knee or shoot the knife out of his hand, that would be sufficient to save yourself and escape the situation. But that would be a violation of precondition B because you would only be acting to save yourself. The problem with saving yourself is that it presumes that your life is more valuable than someone else's. Although,

in reality, you would likely miss and, by shooting, will provoke a lethal reaction from the man. Giving him your wallet is no guarantee of a safe exit from the situation (people are often killed after complying with demands). So, we're left with only option D: Shoot to kill. Ethically, killing the man saves not just yourself, but all of his future victims who may not have been so well armed or sternly principled.

Note: What is ethical and what is legal may come into conflict depending on the local laws in your jurisdiction. I suggest moving to a location where the laws are in minimal conflict with your values.

Non-Attachment

Definition:

The limitation of not basing one's identity on anything external to oneself. This is because anything external to you can be taken away, damaged, destroyed, or simply disregarded. If your identity is entwined with the state or existence of those external things, you will suffer terribly when they are gone.